Running from the Night

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32989507.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Entrapta & Scorpia (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra)

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by DeltaFell

Summary

Adora's been begging Catra to come running with her in the mornings for ages. Catra finally gives in, and when she does, they discover something that threatens everyone living in Bright Moon and turns their lives upside down.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Catra had, for once, decided to go running with Adora in the morning. Catra had been up for about twenty minutes, and already hated everything about it. For one, what fucking lunatic is voluntarily awake at 5 AM? And for another, running sucked balls. Who fucking liked running until your lungs were on fire, and your legs screamed for a rest? What was the point?

"Hey," she panted, "Adora, wait up, I need to rest. Just a bit."

"Sure, Catra. Just a bit," Adora teased.

Catra rested with her hands on her knees. Running, she decided, was definitely not her thing. She never wanted to go on one of these runs again. Not even if Adora paid her. Right as she thought that, Catra felt a shadow pass over her.

"Adora, get out of my sunlight, it's already too cold out this early." Catra looked up to try and find Adora.

Except, Adora was standing in front of her, not behind her where she could block the sunlight. Before Catra could process whatever the hell that meant, a massive dog leapt out of the bushes towards Adora, with crazy raptor talons for nails and huge ears. Just what the fuck was this dog?

"Adora, get down!" Catra leapt towards the dog, all exhaustion forgotten.

Adora dropped flat in a heartbeat, and Catra bodychecked the dog into a tree. As soon as it's body collided against the tree with a dull thud, the strange dog disappeared.

"What the fuck was that?"

Adora looked thoughtful. "I'm not certain. Something about it was familiar to me, I'm not certain why, though, or where from."

"Well, let's get back to the apartment rather than finish the run. I don't want to risk running into another one of those whatever-it-was-es." Catra turned back towards where they had come from.

"We're already past the halfway point, Catra, it'll be faster to just finish the run," Adora said.

"Oh motherfucker."

For the next two weeks, Catra and Adora literally went everywhere together. To the grocery store, to class, hell, they even aligned their work schedules as much as possible so that neither of them was ever alone. Neither Catra nor Adora wanted to risk an encounter with another one of those beasts. Catra

began bringing bear mace in her backpack, while Adora started carrying knives with her.

They spent all their free time in the university library, looking for any references of 'dogs with large ears and raptor claws that could teleport.' Sometimes they would have to go and buy a book referenced in others, if the library and the loans system didn't have it.

One night, after another unsuccessful library trip, Adora remembered where she had recognized that dog from.

"Catra! I know where I know that dog from! Follow me!" Adora sprinted off to where their now-overladen bookshelves lay.

Adora began throwing books aside, digging deep in the bookshelf.

"Adora, what the fuck are you doing?"

"Aha, found it!" Adora emerged from the bookshelf triumphantly lofting a blue-ish book in her hands.

"Adora, what is that?" Catra squinted. "Is that the fucking Monster Manual?"

“Yup!” Adora was positively beaming. She placed the book on the table and began flipping through it.

“How is a fucking D&D book going to help us figure out what the hell this thing is?”

“You’ll see,” Adora flipped through the pages before settling on one. “See, Blink Dog. It looks pretty dang similar to the one that attacked us!”

Catra looked over at the page, surely Adora had to have lost it, right? But no, right there on the middle of the page that said fucking “Blink Dog,” was an illustration of the beast that attacked them.

“What the fuck is going on?”

“I dunno, maybe whoever started D&D did it as a way to like, get the knowledge out? Y’know, give people the tools they need to protect themselves, but like in a way that would actually be helpful? If they had just published a survival guide, it would’ve been laughed off. But by making it a tabletop RPG? People memorized the rules and the mechanics and the weaknesses!”

“Adora what the fuck,” Catra said.

"It makes sense though, just think about it. Blink dogs shouldn't exist, and there's no other surviving literature that references them!"

"I'll think about this, Adora, only if we run into another thing from there that isn't anywhere else," Catra said, "but for now I'm going to bed. I'm fucking tired as shit, and I want a nap."

Catra had, much to her displeasure, been joining Adora for those morning runs regularly. They had switched parks, better safe than sorry, after all, but it made sense to be working out now. After encountering a Blink Dog just jumping her and Adora, Catra wanted to be in good shape so she could fight it off if it came back, or just run. After doing it for a few weeks though, Catra had started to mind the runs less. Her lungs never burned anymore, and her legs barely protested at the end.

Catra still kept bear mace on her. She never knew what might pop out of the forests, be it another Blink Dog, or something worse, so she kept it on her. Things finally calmed down though, and the woods started to be a little less scary in the foggy dew of the morning.

Maybe things would actually be okay.

Of course, as soon as she thought that, a giant purple thing dropped out of the trees above. Being a reasonable person, Catra

maced it to hell and back before sprinting in the other direction.

"Adora, time to go! Turn around, we're not dealing with that! Nope!"

Adora slowed down, got a look at the purple whatever, blanched, and started running in the other direction.

Back at the apartment, Adora consulted the Monster Manual. After some flipping, she seemed to find what she was looking for.

"Here it is, Catra, an 'Ettercap.' I'm glad you sprayed it, these things look like they're really nasty to tangle with."

"Ugh, so your crazy theory might actually be right? I hate it when you're right."

"So, what do we do now?" Adora asked.

"Well, I guess we go through that book, and maybe some other ones, arm ourselves, and keep ourselves safe somehow. We only deal with these things when they show up, and we don't go looking for trouble."

Catra tried to keep them out of it, really she did. Catra knew that if they started actively hunting down the things that go bump in the night, or at least removing the ones that aren't too friendly when they run into regular people, there would be trouble, sooner or later.

But when she and Adora heard some poor kid getting jumped by a pack of knolls, or a young man attacked by a pair of werewolves, or a coven of hags preying on the suburbs, well, they could hardly stand by and watch (or listen, or imagine) it happen. They felt that they had to do something.

And so Catra found herself and Adora intervening more and more, up to the point where they stopped pretending it was about self defense, but protecting others. It felt good, to be saving others, Catra had to admit. She could certainly see the appeal in being a hero.

"So," Catra placed her hands on her hips, "what's the outing for tonight?"

"Well, there's been reports of ravaged animal carcasses in and around the sewers. I think we should investigate whatever is killing those animals, and then determine if it's a threat to people."

"Okay, makes sense. Don't start trying to piece together any of the facts before we've finished investigating, I don't want another Quasit incident." Catra folded her arms.

“It was one time, Catra!”

“And I don’t want it to happen again, Adora! We were very lucky that it wasn’t something worse!”

“Fine, I’ll wait till we’re back here to start theorizing. Now, if you’re happy, let’s get a move on.”

Catra frowned down at the paw prints near the sewer entrance. After the encounter with the blink dog, she had learned the paw print shapes of all the wildlife native to the area around Bright Moon. Nothing had a print this long. If she was right, whatever left these tracks would definitely be a concern. The pattern of the tracks looked more like something that walked on two legs. Nothing good had claws and walked on two legs for more than two meters. Whatever this was walked on two legs most of the time.

“Hey Adora, got anything from looking at the corpses?” Catra called over.

“I think maybe so. This one over here, away from the others looks much worse. There’s far more blood on the ground here, and it has way more gashes than the other corpses. Catra, I think this might have been a bear.”

“Holy shit.”

“Yeah. It has some blood on it’s claws. I’ve grabbed samples of that and some of the bloodstains on the ground. I’m going to take it into the lab along with some blood that I’m pretty certain came from the bear, to see if the bloodstains are from the bear, or our mystery predator.” Adora rubbed her chin.

Something bright caught Catra’s eye as she stood up. A speck of white against a stem. She reached over to grab it, and when she touched it, Catra realized it was a piece of white fur.

“Huh, now that’s interesting.”

“So, what did you get from looking at the blood in the lab, Adora?”

“Well, these four samples,” Adora gestured to four vials marked with serial numbers beginning with A, “all came from our mystery beast. They look very distinct from the bear’s blood under a microscope. Most of the bloodstains, I believe, were the blood of the mystery beast rather than the bear, as only blood gathered from quite near to the bear’s carcass matched the blood of the bear.”

Catra wrote this on a note card, and placed it near a variety of ones she had already prepared.

"Okay, so here's what we know so far: Whatever it is, walks on two legs, with paws longer than most animals. I think it may have white fur," Catra gestured to a baggy holding the white fur that's been stapled to a note card, "the bear was mauled pretty badly, and managed to do some damage back. Based on the spread of the paw prints, I think it would have what the MM calls a move speed of 30. I think that's enough for us to begin trawling through the manual, yeah?"

"Yeah, we're looking for something that could be white, bipedal, but still with claws on its arms and with really long paws. Once we whittle it down to a few potential candidates, let's talk over the potentials?"

"Yup."

Catra flipped through her Monster Manual, looking at anything fur covered and white. The first entry she saw were the lycanthropes. A white werewolf could have been the culprit, but Catra had to keep looking. She had to consider all the possibilities. The next two entries she found that could be her mystery beast were the Quaggoth and the Yeti. Catra flipped through the manual several more times, but found nothing else she believed it could be.

"Okay Adora, I found three potential candidates, lycanthropes, the quaggoth, and the yeti."

“I found the same ones.”

“I think the yeti is the least likely, if you look at the illustration in the MM, you can see that they have feet like monkey paws, and would form a different paw print than what I saw. A white werewolf is a possibility, and a hybrid form would walk on two legs at roughly the pace we saw. However, Quaggoth are prone to wounded furies when near death, according to the stat block. That bear, I think, nearly killed a Quaggoth, and it’s wounded fury killed the bear and then some.”

“Okay that makes sense, I agree with you there. Lycanthrope gear, headlamps, a fire weapon and my silvered knives?”

“Yeah, makes sense. Wednesday work?”

“No, I have that exam Thursday, remember? How about Monday night?”

“I think that’ll do. Monday it is.”

Catra really hated their lycanthrope gear. She could appreciate a reasonable amount of leather, a jacket, maybe some pants, but this was just ridiculous. Their first run in with lycanthropes had

been a lucky one. A posse of werebears had been going on rampages throughout the suburbs, fixing condemned buildings and repairing houses. Adora and Catra had gone in expecting a fight, but ended up with a lecture.

Apparently, most lycanthropes actually dislike spreading their curse, but just in case, wearing multiple layers of leather or preferably stab-resistant kevlar could help protect them if a bite managed to land. Catra chuckled to herself. Those werebears clearly didn't get the whole 'college students fighting mythical beasts' memo, because there was no way they could afford stab resistant kevlar. That shit was fucking expensive.

So, here she was, wearing several layers of leather because there might be a werewolf in the fucking sewers below Bright Moon. At least Adora looked kinda hot in leather. The only redeeming trait of lycanthrope gear was getting to see her roommate in leather. Adora hated wearing leather, but damn if she didn't look kickass in it.

"You ready to go yet?"

Catra turned around, and Adora was standing there in her doorway, waiting for Catra. Catra swallowed, just glancing at Adora in lycanthrope gear was hard. Adora had strapped her set of silvered knives to her belt, three inch, five inch, and seven inch silvered blades glimmering. She held Catra's silver lighter in an outstretched hand. Of course this dork grabbed the lighter that matched her blades.

“Yeah, I’m ready.”

“Aww, do you not like all this leather? What’s wrong, Miss punk girl? Can’t take all the leather?” Adora smirked.

“Shut up, you know how I feel about lycanthrope gear. Besides, this means we can take my bike.” Catra smiled as the smirk wiped itself off Adora’s face.

Catra walked out to the street, grabbing her lighter out of Adora’s hand, strapping on her helmet, and sliding her bear mace into the holster she made for it. It might not kill them, but lycanthropes really hated bear mace. If she set the spray on fire, it was even worse.

Catra hopped onto her bike, and once Adora had hopped on behind her she took off down the road. Catra loved the feeling of riding her bike. The freedom in the night, the wind whipping against her throughout the ride.

Catra flicked on her flashlight. They were entering the sewers near where the carcasses had been found. Odds were, whatever beasts were down here weren’t too far from where they either dumped their kills for the scavengers, or where they ate.

It was late, but that was necessary. Quaggoths were nocturnal, making this more dangerous, but lycanthropes often went

unshifted during the day, and if this were a werewolf or a werewolf pack, they may not be able to be able to differentiate between a squatter or an unshifted werewolf. Leaving werewolves in this pack alive, if they were a malicious one, would be a lethal mistake. And given that they lived in the sewers, Catra doubted they were up to anything good.

Catra heard the click-clack of claws on the tile. She clipped her flashlight to the side of her helmet and called out to Adora, "We've got contact, knives out, Adora!"

Catra could hear Adora unsheathe her two longer knives. Good, her shorter knife would be a dangerous game if there were lycanthropes down here. Catra drew her can of bear mace, and grabbed her lighter in her free hand. Catra saw a second beam of light flare out on the sewer walls as Adora turned on her headlight.

As Catra looked down the sewer tunnel, she saw something with pale fur, and a tall bipedal form. It didn't have any tattered clothing, and the paws on its arms weren't even remotely human-like. She swore.

"Dammit, Adora, we've got quaggoths! Form one!" she shouted.

Adora found her, and placed her back against Catra's. They had developed form one for fighting against pack creatures. They would fight back to back, so nothing could get behind them. It meant they usually got surrounded, but that was likely inevitable

against creatures that hunted in groups. This way at least, they could watch each other's backs.

Catra took in a deep breath, and the dance began. She certainly loved all the good they did hunting these monsters, but one of her favorite parts was simply the fighting. She had always enjoyed martial arts, but nothing compared to being able to just truly let loose.

A quaggoth charged her, swiping with its claws. She ducked beneath the claws, before kicking one of its knees out from under it and macing it to hell. Quaggoths probably had pretty sensitive senses of smell, spraying one in the face with bear mace might overwhelm its senses and hopefully keep it out of the fight long enough for Adora to slit its throat. Catra would rather save her lighter trick for later in the fight. She didn't want to risk triggering a quaggoth's fury this early in the fight, that could seriously endanger her and Adora.

As the fight continued, Catra realized that macing the quaggoths was not nearly as effective as she had hoped. Some of the first ones she maced were starting to get back up before she and Adora were even halfway through the tribe. Catra flicked open her lighter, and a little flame appeared. As she heard Adora's knives thud into another quaggoth, Catra sprayed the bear mace through the open flame of her lighter.

The effect was instantaneous. A massive fireball burst into existence right before her, consuming four quaggoths in seconds. Unfortunately, the bright flare of light also blinded her, but probably not nearly as bad as the nearby quaggoths. Quaggoths had excellent night vision, according to the monster manual.

Hopefully that would leave them extra vulnerable to bright flashes of light like the one she had just caused

As she blinked away the spots from her vision, Catra saw that most of the quaggoths were still blinded. She leapt into action, trying to disable or kill as many quaggoths as possible before they regained their vision. Catra was a blur, snapping leg bones and bashing in skulls.

Before she knew it, the fight was over. Adora and her had put down all the quaggoths. Catra's breathing, while fast, was no longer ragged after a fight. The outer layers of Adora's leather were shredded, but none of the claws had found her skin. Catra's leather was untouched, a point she took some pride in. She took a minute to calm her pulse, and began looking around.

"Adora, do you see any symbols carved into the sewer walls, or maybe some crates?"

Adora's headlamp shook in the background. "No, I can't find anything."

"Neither can I. Maybe these quaggoth were just a wild tribe, and not sent by the drow?"

"I guess that's a possibility."

“Alright, well let’s get you home Adora. You don’t want to get your sleep schedule too out of whack before your big exam.”

“I’m not a little kid anymore Catra, I can handle a little fluctuation in my sleep schedule,” Adora protested.

“Sure you can, princess,” Catra said.

They returned to the surface shoving and laughing, high off their recent victory. Some of the shadows looked a little odd in the moonlight, but Catra figured that was just her eyes playing tricks on her.

It had been a few weeks since the quaggoth case when the consequences of their adventures started to catch up to them. After driving Adora to a big chemistry exam, Catra returned to her bike to find her tires had been slashed. While Adora was quick to write it off as someone being a dick - ‘I mean you do ride a motorcycle, Catra, and bikers are pretty unpopular here’- Catra was less willing to do so. The slash marks in her bike’s tires looked a lot more like claws than knife slashes.

The morning she found bones on their porch, Catra knew something was going on. They had been arranged to form the word stop. Somebody knew what they were getting up to in their free time, and this somebody didn’t like it.

Adora and Catra called the police, who were suspicious and unhelpful, but when Catra asked Entrapta to hack into the police database to find out what was really going on, she found out that these were human bones, connected to a dozen different cold cases across Etheria.

This was bad. Whoever had found them not only knew where they lived, but was clearly okay with killing people. This was very bad. Of course, it hardly stopped them, the monsters were still out there terrorizing the people of Bright Moon, but it certainly made them a little more cautious. They texted friends where they were going to be (roughly, and never told them what they were really doing) when they went out hunting. They got better equipment when they could afford it, and Adora had started saving up for kevlar stab vests for the both of them. They were going to be stupid expensive, but Adora was convinced they would be worth it.

When Catra and Adora found the note on the door, she knew the game had changed. Whatever had happened, there was no way they could continue on as they had before.

The contents of the note confirmed her fears. Adora began to cry when she read it, and the words struck dread into Catra's heart.

'We have kidnapped your friends Glimmer Moon and Bow Archer. Unless you surrender yourselves over to us on the night of the full moon by one am, we will turn them, and set them after you. When you surrender yourselves to us, meet us at the biggest warehouse in the shipping district. - The Pack'

“What are we going to do Catra? We can’t let them get hurt because of our dumb choices,” Adora sobbed.

“No, we can’t. But we can’t just lie down and die for these assholes either.” Catra had an idea and pulled out her phone.

She opened the Super Pal Trio group chat and began texting.

‘Come over to my apartment immediately. Adora needs the Super Pal Trio, and frankly, so do I.’

While they waited for Scorpia and Entrapta to come over, Adora paced constantly. She was a nervous wreck, already wearing her lycanthrope gear and fidgeting with her silvered knives. Adora had bought two more copies of the Monster Manual earlier that day, and now had them out on their table.

“Adora, sit down and I’ll grab one of your fidgets, not the knives. You’re just going to end up regretting all this pacing in the morning, and you might damage the silvering on your knives if you keep playing with them like that,” Catra said, already reaching for the shelf where they kept Adora’s fidget materials.

Adora nodded, and then reluctantly sat down on their couch, still within eyesight of their front door. Catra handed her a fidget cube,

and Adora immediately took to spinning it and clicking it's buttons.

When the knock finally came, Catra got up to get the door. Adora leapt up like she had been shocked, but Catra pushed her back down. Adora reluctantly complied.

Catra opened the door. "Hey you guys, it's good to see you."

"Hey," Scorpia was deceptively gentle for her size, physically and emotionally. "What do you guys need?"

"Come inside and we'll talk."

As they stepped inside, Entrapta spotted the Monster Manuals sitting on the table, "Oh! Is this an emergency D&D game? I love emergency D&D games! I can help cheer my friends up by doing something I'm good at!"

Scorpia, however, was frozen slack jawed. She had caught sight of Adora's lycanthrope gear. "Since when did you wear leather, Adora? I thought you hated it. And why do you have so many knives strapped to you? What's going on guys?"

Catra shut the apartment door behind them. She sighed, "This is going to sound absurd, but trust me, everything I'm about to tell you is completely true."

“Wildcat, I don’t like this at all, what’s going on?”

“Most of the creatures in the Monster Manual are, well, real. They exist and they haunt Bright Moon. Adora and I have, for the past few months, been trying to protect the people of Bright Moon. A few weeks ago, a group left a message on our front porch in human bones. Then, today, we believe the same group kidnapped Glimmer and Bow, leaving a note on our door.”

“This is a lot to take in, Wildcat, I dunno.” Scorpia said.

Entrapta spoke up, “No, no, this makes sense. Bright Moon, and several other major cities have an unusually high rating of reported supernatural sightings and unsolved lethal crimes. Plus, combined with the fact that the bones from the cold cases all had markings like they had been chewed by startlingly big animals.”

“You found all that in the police report?”

“Well, no, they had almost nothing but some pictures of the bones, and their identities. I got curious so I did some looking.”

“Just some looking?” Catra asked.

Entrapta looked confused. “Yeah, should I have done more?”

“No, ‘Trapta, you did plenty. I just, I didn’t expect you to call that ‘just some’ looking.”

“So, how can we help?” Scorpia asked.

“Well, we’re gonna need to get you some leather jackets and pants, for one. We’re not certain what this group is, but we think they might be lycanthropes. It would certainly fit their motifs, and at least one of them can write, read, and pass for a normal human enough to place this note on our door in the middle of broad daylight. ‘Trapta, do you still have the thermite and napalm from last year?

Entrapta cackled, “Oh you know I do.”

“Okay, we’ll want to pick that up from your apartment. Probably get you a can of bear mace if we can find some.”

Catra turned to face Scorpia. “Do you still have that shock baton?”

“Yeah, it's in my car still.”

“Good, you’re going to need it. Once we have all that, I think we can begin planning.”

It was the night of the full moon. Catra, Adora, Entrapta and Scorpia had done everything they possibly could to prepare for the night. They just had to hope it was enough prep work to get them through alive.

Catra and Adora drove there on her motorcycle, while Scorpia and Entrapta took Scorpia's van earlier in the day. The location was pretty easy to figure out, being the Freight Zone warehouse. It was easily the biggest one in the shipping district, and there were plenty of alleyways nearby for Scorpia and Entrapta to hide in until the fighting began, where they could jump out and surprise the mystery group.

Catra and Adora pulled up to the front of the warehouse. Several humanoids with boar tusks stood in a circle around two kneeling humanoids with hoods over their heads and a massive bonfire. Standing behind who presumably were Glimmer and Bow was a hooded figure. Catra couldn't make out any details about this figure, as the bonfire made them more of a silhouette than anything else.

"Okay you assholes, we're here! Now let Glimmer and Bow go!" Catra shouted.

A rough chorus of deep laughter arose from the wereboars.

"Oh you foolish girls, you think we ever planned on letting them go? No, we will simply keep the four of you," said the strange

figure before the bonfire.

Catra chuckled and drew her bear mace. “We thought you might say that.”

Behind her, Adora drew her knives from their sheaths, and began running towards the wereboars. Catra sprinted forwards, keeping even with Adora. As soon as she reached a wereboar, she sprayed it with her bear mace. It shrieked in pain, collapsing and clawing at its face. To her left, she could hear Adora’s blades clink on ivory and thud into flesh and bone.

They fought in a whirl towards the captive Bow and Glimmer. Once they reached the pair, Catra called out, “Entrapta, we have them! Time to get them out!”

Headlights flicked on, facing the ring of wereboars, and Entrapta laughed, “Oh this is going to be absolutely fascinating! Now, let’s get weird!”

Entrapta drove the van forward at maximum acceleration, straight towards the group. As she approached the ring, she violently swerved the van, turning it so that the side of the van directly impacted several of the wereboars.

“Entrapta, how? That should be impossible!” Catra dodged one of the wereboars that Entratpta sent flying.

Entrapta’s eyes gleamed in the firelight. “I made some modifications!”

Scorpia slid open one of the doors and hopped out, stun baton swinging. Scorpia grabbed Bow and slung him under one arm while Catra grabbed Glimmer under both of her arms and held her against her chest. Adora’s knives sung through the air, making bright clangs and dull thuds when they impacted.

“Hurry up, I don’t want to get surrounded with Glimmer and Bow in the van!”

“I’m working on it, Entrapta!” Catra said as she pushed Glimmer into the van.

As soon as Glimmer was in, Scorpia gently deposited Bow in, closed the door, and rapped on the outside of the van door three times. At the sound of the agreed upon signal, Entrapta sped off, Bow and Glimmer safely inside.

The menacing purple van gone, the wereboars circled back in around Adora, Scorpia and Catra. Scorpia clicked her stun baton, and charged one, whacking it repeatedly until it fell over.

“Nobody. Takes. My. Friends!” she shouted.

Catra flicked open her lighter, willing to really cause some damage now that Glimmer and Bow were out of here. Behind her, she could hear Adora pant lightly. She had really been going to town, and was the only one who could really dispatch the wereboars before Catra got out her lighter.

For a while they were winning, Entrapta circling the van around the area, chucking flaming ball jars at any wereboars who got too close. But then they started to get tired. None of their fights had ever lasted this long, and while Scorpia boxed, even this was starting to get tiring for her.

Adora was thrown by a wereboar that ignored her knives long enough to grab her. She flew backwards, one of her knives embedded in its forearm. When Adora landed, Catra heard a sickening crunch.

Catra took off towards where Adora lay, heart in her throat. Adora couldn’t be dead, she just couldn’t.

Fortunately, as Catra drew near, Adora sat up groggily. Her helmet fell apart, and Adora held a hand to her head. “Ow. My head kinda hurts.”

Catra laughed, “C’mon and get up dummy, we’ve gotta finish this fight.”

Rejuvenated, Catra fought twice as hard against the remaining wereboars. They whittled it down to just the mysterious figure, who, now that they were closer, could see was wearing red robes. Before they could corner this mysterious figure, however, they threw a pendant into the bonfire and fled.

Adora leapt forward to grab the pendant, and managed to block Catra from chasing the mysterious figure down.

"Adora, you dummy, you got in my way," Catra trailed off mid-sentence, "Adora, what is that on your cheek?"

Adora reached up to feel her cheek and her eyes widened when she touched a red streak there.

"Oh no."

"Adora, did they get you? Adora?" Catra's voice began to shake.

"I- I'm not sure." Adora clutched the pendant tightly.

"We'll have to wait until the full moon and see if you transform. Fuck, Adora, what are we gonna do?"

Adora walked over to Catra and clutched her hands. “What we have to.”

Catra, Scorpia, Entrapta, Glimmer, and Bow all wore lycanthrope gear on the night of the full moon as they drove Adora out to a secluded forest in Plumeria. Adora had basically never let go of that pendant they got from the mysterious figure, who they had taken to calling Shadow, because it sounded about edgy enough for that creep. Catra found the pendant’s bull headed shape made her kinda uneasy, but if it made Adora more comfortable, well, who was she to deny her it.

They set up in the forest with lights around Adora, and each of them sitting in various trees, far enough away that Adora couldn’t see them. Catra waited for the moon to rise, sick to her stomach. She really didn’t want to have to figure out what to do if Adora had been infected.

The moon rose and nothing happened. Adora sat there, just as nervous, waiting for something terrible to begin. But it never came. The moon rose and sank, and Adora’s body never shifted.

Catra jumped out of her tree and rushed towards Adora, hugging her when she got there. Adora stiffened slightly at the unexpected touch, before hugging back.

“You know what, I’m not waiting any more, I love you Catra,” sobbed Adora.

“I love you too, dummy,” Catra said, also crying into Adora’s shoulder.

The two simply sat there in the forest, hugging and crying until they both felt spent. On the walk back to the van, they were laughing and crying. They both knew they had dodged a bullet that day, and they wanted to make sure they got the most out of every remaining minute.

End Notes

So this story received a lot of inspiration from the Dresden Files. It's one of my favorite series of all time, and it just keeps giving. I'm a huge urban fantasy fan (if you couldn't already tell) and I really wanted to tell one where the main characters didn't have like proper weapons, not because of any magic rules (Celestial bronze in PJO, magicians making shit break in DF) but because weapons are fucking expensive. Like good knives, not even ones that would make good weapons just decent quality tools, are well over 100 bucks. To a college student, that's like four weeks of food. Guns are like in the thousands of dollars! Kevlar stab vests, such as mentioned this chapter? 300-400 dollars, way out of a student's budget, especially if they're trying to afford rent. Special weapons/inability to use regular ones are staples of urban fantasy, and I kinda wanted to turn that on it's head here.

Adora and Catra will return.

Thanks to everyone who read, kudos'd or even commented, your love fuels the forges of writing!

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